



THE UNCERTAINTY AROUND THE INDIAN SQUAD IS THE FACT THAT OF ALL THE NINE SHOOTERS, ONLY AIR RIFLEMAN GAGAN NARANG HAS HAD A SATISFYING 2008.



APR PHOTO: MANAN VATSYAYANA

MISSING

RONJON SODHI: In June, Sodhi, 28, won gold at the Belgrade World Cup with a world-record equalling score. It was Indian shooting's best result in 2008 but Sodhi will not be in Beijing because India's Olympic quota slots are already full and the International Shooting Federation's Olympic wild cards had already been awarded. A philosophical Sodhi says, "It's all about destiny. I'm in good form now but I should have been in good form earlier and should have won my quota place in 2004-05."



SHOOTING STARS: Bhagwat (left) has returned; Sandhu goes in as a world champ

Suma Shirur) reached the finals. "If we have more than three finalists this time," he says, "we will win more medals. I'm sure of that." The gnawing uncertainty around the Olympic team is the fact that only Gagan Narang has had a satisfying run in Beijing. In April, he won a bronze at the Beijing World Cup held as an Olympics test event.

Most cruelly, India's best shooter this year, Ronjon Sodhi, will be watching the Olympics from his living room in Delhi (*see box*). It looks like a bad omen. Rifle coach Laszlo Szucsak, a reassuringly large and calm Hungarian, says there's no reason to be reading Chinese tea leaves yet.

Form, he said, could work in mysterious ways, and his shooters' scores in practice had shown a climb which makes him optimistic. "Even the Chinese are keeping themselves back this year. Everybody wants to be hungry for the Olympics."

India, too, has been starving for its Olympic medals, so much so that Mansher Singh says the team can sense it "in the eyes of the officials, of the Government, people who know you". No matter how many World Cups or World Championships they win, the shooters know those metal discs from the Olympics ensure immortality.



MANAVJIT SINGH

No wonder they've sweated bullets. World trap champion Manavjit Singh Sandhu hasn't eaten a sweet, not one, for more than 10 months now. Bindra sat inside a police station in Nanjing Airport for nine hours (also three hours in Beijing airport, he informs you helpfully) waiting for his gun clearance, telling himself that this was probably a trial of his forbearance. "The shotgun guys would probably have thrown things, made a noise. But we rifle-shooters are patient."

Rathore has changed coaches and shut the wider world out of life. While his teammates were training in Kuala Lumpur, he was breathing in the air around the Beijing Shooting Range.

Since winning their berths, the lives of every member of this team is a narrative in isolation and self-discovery. Mansher Singh often dreams of a Games where India will win five or six medals. "More we evolve as a sporting nation, easier it'll get for our athletes." Szucsak is ready to lend his cupboard-sized shoulders for the shooters to lean on. "It's always more difficult for the first generation that breaks the barriers and challenges the world." In Athens, Rathore crashed through the barriers. At the end of Indian shooting's season of uncertainty, Chilly could do with some company. ■